

Alphonsa's sainthood comes as a very good news.
MAYA CHIDANAND, on e-mail

The hue and cry over conversions has sparked another communal carnage in different parts of the country. However, in such difficult times, the canonisation of sister Alphonsa has accorded Christians an occasion to rejoice.

VIRENDRA KUMAR TANGRI, on e-mail

Warring Women

It is fight to finish for two most powerful women in political arena—the bahu, Sonia Gandhi, and the behenji, Mayawati. While one heads India's oldest political party, the other is the voice, loud and clear, of the Dalits ("Bahu Vs Behenji", October 27). Sonia is sophisticated in her manners and more often than not, politically right, while Maya, the true daughter of the land, has been able to keep her flock together with her rustic charm. A sharp contrast in their personalities, but both have undoubtedly the same aspirations—gain political clout at the expense of the other. They leave no opportunity to outwit each other and the recent fiasco between the two over land allotment, cancellation and then again compromise was another battle aimed at gaining political mileage.

ROHIT KUMAR, on e-mail

Apathy Reigns

Why has the Government become so indifferent to the plight of the 21 members aboard the MV

Stolt Valor ("The Hijack Dilemma", October 27)? Time and again, the Government is proving its impotence and also the undeniable truth that neither can it act tough on terrorism nor can it tackle maritime hazards like the attack by Somali pirates.

ADITYA DEEKONDA, Bangalore

Shades of Religion

It is really unfortunate to witness the plight of our nation at the hands of such misguided youth who are

wreaking havoc with their action ("Inside the Mind of the Bombers", October 13). Members of fundamentalist groups like SIMI and Indian Mujahideen and also the Bajrang Dal ("The Rogue Army", October 13) are bombing metros, burning down churches, invoking mayhem in the name of religion. These self-proclaimed ambassadors of almighty are spoiling the secular fabric of our country with their evil deeds.

GAURAB GOSWAMI, on e-mail

SURVIVAL TACTICS



HK RAJASHEKAR

DMK, just like any other coalition partner, is good at using arm-twisting tactics like offering resignations and threatening to withdraw support to the UPA Government to have its way ("Tiger by the Tail", October 27). It is more because of political compulsions that it is opposing the Government's stance of giving military aid to Sri Lanka which, it alleges, hasn't done any good to the Tamils living there.

A. SRIKANTIAH, Bangalore

The Tigers have carried out more suicide bombings than the Hamas and the Al Qaida put together. They have killed more Tamils than anyone else. India should refrain from being swayed by the DMK's pressure and remain firm in its stand.

J.S. ACHARYA, Hyderabad

India should stay away from the current imbroglio. The LTTE must bear the fury of the Lankan military.

SWADESH SHARMA, Bhopal

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Porn Power

Unobtrusively at first, then, like a collective literary orgasm, the country's reading public has suddenly been blitzed with an avalanche of commercialised smut. In what is a salacious parody of the political pornography that blossomed in the wake of the Emergency, the last few months have witnessed an explosive demonstration of porn power. Originally confined to a plethora of cheap, lurid regional-language publications, booksellers in India's major cities now have a bewildering array of sexy magazines to attract passing voyeurs. Under-the-counter, back issues of *Playboy*, *Penthouse* and *Hustler* have lost pride of place to indigenous products like *Hot Wave*, *Confidential Adviser*, *Garam Kahaniyan* and the seemingly innocuous *For All* and *Film Mirror*. From the small local presses of Belgaum and Pune come a torrent of earthy, Marathi periodicals including the better known *Apsara*, while Ahmedabad churns out its own grotty editions of *Vyanglok*, *Youwani Malai*, *Mamta* and *Rasna*. The best represented state on the stalls, however, is Tamil Nadu.

—Dillip Bobb